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Using Feminist Family Therapy and a Multidisciplinary Collaboration to Address Issues Regarding Sexism in Gamers

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ABSTRACT

Sexism in video games is present in pop culture. Female video game characters are sexualized, objectified, and made to seem less important as opposed to their male counterparts (Burgess, Stermer, & Burgess, 2007; Dill, Brown, & Collins, 2008; Dill & Thill, 2007; Martins, Williams, Harrison, & Ratan, 2009; Scharrer, 2004). We propose that marriage and family therapists use feminist family therapy to address video games' sexist content as it relates to sexism within relationships, specifically through feminist family therapy principles of egalitarian relationships, power, women's strengths, acceptance, and validation. Furthermore, we promote the multidisciplinary collaboration with marriage and family therapists and video game developers, industry professionals, and the gaming community to improve gender equality and reduce sexism within video games.

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Introduction

Playing video games has become an important part of American culture (Wolf, 2017). Since their first appearance in 1971 as a commercially-available product in arcades and then their entrance in 1972 into homes through home video game systems, video games have integrated well into American society (Wolf, 2017). This is likely due to coinciding cultural values of competitiveness, fast-paced movement, personal identity, and novelty in both the U.S. and video game cultures (Wolf, 2017). Today, video games have continued to remain a technology beloved by many Americans as the quality of games has increased and as the integration of movie characters into the video game arena has allowed consumers to connect with other cherished aspects of popular culture (Wolf, 2017).

Due to the high regard that many Americans hold toward video games, marriage and family therapists should be aware of the popularity of video games and how these influence society and the relationships within them. Systemic societal issues such as sexism and misogyny are present in many video games. It is vital that marriage and family therapists work to address

issues of sexism in video games with couples who are also finding issues of sexism within their relationship. Using feminist family therapy is one such way to do so. We propose that marriage and family therapists use concepts from video games to address themes related to egalitarian relationships, power, women's strengths, and acceptance and validation within relationships. Additionally, we propose that marriage and family therapists take an active role in working with video game developers, industry professionals, and the gaming community to reduce sexism within video games, which may have a more positive effect on the view of all women, including trans women within relationships and society at large.

Literature review

Video game usage

According to the Entertainment Software Association (2017), 65% of households contain an individual who plays video games for at least 3 hours each week. Not only are video games being played regularly by many individuals, but the devices used to play video games, including computers, Smartphones, and gaming consoles, are also reported to be owned by 67% of U.S. households (Entertainment Software Association, 2017). Out of those who play video games, many decide to play with other people, as there is an average of two gamers in each household, with a reported 17% of gamers playing with their spouse, 21% playing with family members, and 18% playing with parents (Entertainment Software Association, 2017). Furthermore, 46% of gamers report that it helps family spend time together (Electronic Software Association, 2018). These statistics demonstrate how important video games are to Americans and that oftentimes these video games are used as a way to spend time and build connections within family and couple relationships.

The average ages of the female and male gamer are 36 and 32, respectively, with 45% of United States gamers being women (Electronic Software Association, 2018). In fact, adult women specifically are playing more video games than boys under the age of 18 years old (Electronic Software Association, 2018). These statistics directly counter many stereotypes that suggest that games are solely consumed by young men, but it should also be noted that the Electronic Software Association does not extend their research on which games people of all genders play.

There are a variety of video game genres to which video game players subscribe. Bestselling video game genres include shooters (25.9%), action (21.9%), sports (11.6%), role playing (11.3%), and less than 10% for adventure, racing, fighting, and strategy games. The most played multiplayer genres include shooter games (e.g., *Halo* and *Call of Duty*) which account for 35%, action games (e.g., *League of Legends* and *World of Warcraft*) which account for 28%, and

casual games (e.g., *Candy Crush* and *Castle Crashers*) which account for 27% (Electronic Software Association, 2018). Some multiplayer genres such as real-time strategy, first-person shooters, fighting games, and multiplayer online battle arenas continue to rise in popularity within mainstream culture while also perpetuating ongoing gender disparities, marginalizing practices for female gamers, and failing to address a sexist and harassing online community that creates a hostile space for female gamers (Consalvo, 2012; Ratan, Taylor, Hogan, Kennedy, & Williams, 2015).

Sexism in video games

When video games were initially released, the graphics of the era were not as technologically advanced as they are today; as such, the majority of video games released between 1983 and 1990 contained characters that were the least sexualized among a sample of video game characters from past and present (Lynch, Tompkins, van Driel, & Fritz, 2016). In fact, it was not until the mid-1990s that female characters began to be graphically designed to appear more sexualized to appeal to a male-dominated industry (Lynch et al., 2016).

In many video games, sexism and negative gender stereotypes are apparent in the appearance of the characters, especially among those characters categorized as female. These characters are often designed to perfection, looking what is considered as beautiful and flawless with large breasts, a thin body type and wearing revealing clothing (Burgess, Stermer, & Burgess, 2007; Dill, Brown, & Collins, 2008; Dill & Thill, 2007; Martins, Williams, Harrison, & Ratan, 2009; Scharrer, 2004). Dill and Thill (2007) described women in video games being portrayed as “objects of men’s heterosexual fantasies” and “less important than men” (p. 861). Even if the female characters were classified as violent characters, they were still objectified and made to seem less important, which detracted from the notion of being a “true figure of liberation” (Dill & Thill, 2007, p. 861).

Apart from appearance, female videogame characters were reported to be given fewer primary roles important to the video game’s main storyline (Lynch et al., 2016). Lynch and colleagues (2016) reported that while there are more playable female characters in video games overall, there is still a lack of primary female characters, including characters who are seen as the hero (Dill, Gentile, Richter, & Dill, 2005; Scharrer, 2004). In fact, literature suggests that women in video games are often underrepresented and marginalized (Dill et al., 2008, 2005; Scharrer, 2004). This may send a message that the female characters within the game are less important, less competent, and inferior to both the male characters and the males who are often playing those characters.

In contrast to female characters, male characters were designed to appear physically powerful, dominant, mean, and aggressive (Dill & Thill, 2007).

Unlike their female counterparts, male characters were not seen as sex objects and were given more respect (Dill & Thill, 2007). Lynch et al. (2016) states that overtly sexualized female characters mainly belongs to the fighting genre of video games, which is a genre that is primarily marketed towards men.

According to Lynch and colleagues (2016) criticisms of the male-dominated gaming industry have emerged, by both female players and developers, which contributes to a shift in some sexualizing and sexist content. Even so, it is imperative that marriage and family therapists continue this work of challenging sexism in the ever-growing video game community, especially because of its effects on individuals, families, and couples.

The effect of video game sexism on individuals

Several studies have reported effects on video game players as a result of playing video games containing elements of sexism. It was suggested in one of these studies that female gamers have less confidence in their ability to succeed in the real world after playing a sexualized female heroine (Behm-Morawitz & Mastro, 2009). Subtle sexualization of women in video games may also lead to higher self-objectification and acceptance of rape myths in female gamers (Lynch et al., 2016). In fact, Dill et al. (2008) discovered that long-term violent video game usage was often correlated with more rape-supportive attitudes. Furthermore, both male and female gamers rated women as less cognitively and physically capable when compared to men after playing a sexualized female video game character (Behm-Morawitz & Mastro, 2009). Moreover, males who were exposed to sexualized female characters tended to be more tolerant of sexual harassment of a woman, and women were found to be less tolerant (Dill et al., 2008). Males who played video games with sexist elements also tended to uphold ideas of benevolent sexism, which is characterized by beliefs that women must be protected and are socially inferior to men; this effect was not found among female players (Stermer & Burkley, 2015).

The effect of video game sexism in relationships

While research currently exists that looks at the effect of sexism within video games on individuals, it is presently lacking in regard to the relational components of how video game sexism affects couples and families. Even so, as marriage and family therapists, it is important to remember that effects on individuals provide a context for relationships in which they are affected as well. This is to say that video game sexism, as previously discussed, has an effect on individuals. These individuals are then a part of relational systems and those effects of sexism from video games influence their interactions with their partners and/or other members of their families.

Furthermore, while research currently does not examine sexism deriving from video games on couple and family relationships, research does look at the effects of sexism on couple and family relationships. In heterosexual couple relationships, men's use of benevolent sexism led to women not having as much support to pursue independent goals as well as women feeling less competent (Hammond & Overall, 2015). Benevolent sexism also was negatively associated with relationship satisfaction in heterosexual relationships (Casad, Salazar, & Macina, 2015). Additionally, men's utilization of hostile sexism led to an increase in resistance and hostility in both partners during conflict interactions (Overall, Sibley, & Tan, 2011). In families, mothers who held hostile sexist ideology were more likely to participate in maternal gatekeeping and engage in gendered division of childcare (Gaunt & Pinho, 2018).

Considering that most gamers play or speak with others while playing, video game sexism is experienced relationally and systemically often. In multiplayer gaming, online harassment of women and people of other genders is a prevalent issue that impact gamers today. Many women consider online gaming, and some gaming in general to be men's spaces with women interloping in those spaces (Cote, 2017). Day-to-day harassment including sexualized insults, threats of assaults and other offensive experiences were reported (Cote, 2017). Assimilation in gaming occurs frequently even in environments with partners, friends, and coworkers as seen with use of pseudonyms, concealing of one's gender, and other tactics to avoid harassment.

Marriage and family therapists need to be aware that video game playing is an important part of American culture and its effects on the family are, indeed, a contemporary issue that should be addressed in therapy and research. These studies demonstrate both the need for additional research and for that research to have a relational and systemic framework. Therefore, the exploration of possible negative effects that sexism or sexualization have on a player can be addressed within therapeutic contexts and the scope of feminism.

Feminist family therapy

Feminism and its principles can be applied to any school of thought in family therapy, but Corey (2005) asserts that feminist therapists integrate feminism into their approach to therapy and into their lives. Despite the fact that most practitioners are sensitive to gender issues and consider themselves nonsexist, it is the therapists who practice gender equality as their main focus that are considered feminist therapists (Nichols, 2013). It is this sensitivity to gender issues and awareness of gender roles and beliefs among other things that highlight this theoretical orientation.

Feminist family therapy ideals initially emerged after scholars critically analyzed the double bind theory when case examples of this theory were applied to the mothers of patients with schizophrenia; specifically, how the mothers were exclusively to blame for cause of this mental illness (McGeorge, Carlson, & Wetchler, 2015). This notion not only upheld gender bias in the emergence of family therapy development but was then reinforced due to the pioneers of the field emphasizing basic assumptions of gender and patriarchal ideas in family therapy literature (McGeorge et al., 2015). In terms of intersectionality, this foundational literature and early family therapy thought can be subtly problematic as they dominate our field today and were created by prominent white males of the field, without much input by women, including trans women and women of color. The act of challenging foundational theories in the family therapy field emerged in the late 1970s allowing it to be deliberately political by replacing patriarchal ideas and emphasizing equality and feminist consciousness (McGeorge et al., 2015; Nichols, 2013).

Walker (1990) proposed that there were six main principles that are applied in feminist therapy, including egalitarian relationships, power, enhancing women's strengths, taking a non-pathological and non-victim blaming stance, education, and acceptance and validation of feelings. Regarding egalitarian relationships, the therapist uses his/her own relationship with the clients to model how egalitarian relationships can function (Walker, 1990). Therapists also help women use and analyze power in their relationships, as well as analyze and strengthen the positive aspects that all women possess (Walker, 1990). A stance in which women are not victim-blamed or pathologized is also important to feminist therapy, according to Walker, by viewing problems as a function of surviving within the social context (Walker, 1990). The promotion of education as well as the acceptance and validation of feelings, including through therapeutic self-disclosure are applied to feminist therapy as well (Walker, 1990). We later propose that these themes should be considered when treating gamers who encounter sexism with feminist family therapy.

Feminist family therapy today, as it is applied in therapeutic and clinical contexts, creates space for people to examine their assumptions of gender with sensibility rather than indoctrination (i.e. a feminist therapist imposing their position onto clients) (Nichols, 2013). According to Nichols (2013), feminist family therapy has many benefits including helping people rethink their relationship with their bodies by looking at the effects of social expectations placed onto them by the media. Video game media and oversexualized messages that games portray is not excluded from this. Feminist family therapists also invite clients to gain an understanding of problems within society such as sexism and harassment and empower them to take an active role in that process (Nichols, 2013).

Thus, we propose using feminist family therapy to address sexism in gamers while reaching out to the community by using a multidisciplinary

approach. Using empowerment techniques as a core to help people of all genders differentiate between what they have been taught is socially acceptable in video games and media and what is actually in their best interest (Nichols, 2013). Mutual empowerment then will be emphasized by using feminist family therapy techniques. Last, our feminism has intersectional considerations to accommodate marginalized groups within the gaming community by the emphasis on individual and societal change.

Using feminist family therapy to address sexism in gaming

Because sexism is present in gaming and because sexism can affect individuals, couples, and families, it is proposed that feminist family therapy is used to address this issue. Additionally, we suggest that attuning to egalitarian relationships, power and disempowerment, enhancing women's strengths, and accepting and validating feelings are beneficial to explore and dismantle sexism that is presenting in gaming. Case examples will be provided for each section to provide clarity and information about applying these themes in therapy.

Egalitarian relationships

Feminist family therapists look at how power can be equally distributed within the relationship (Walker, 1990). As previously mentioned, a lot of the female video game characters are not central to the main storyline of the video game (Lynch et al., 2016). This may send a message to gamers that men are more important. This, in turn, may influence and perpetuate a hierarchy in relationships wherein men are deemed more important and more respected. This creates a situation in which partners are perceived as unequal to men. While this message can be received from across multiple contexts, changing the understood message in at least one context, namely video games, may help bring awareness and change (if so desired) to the state of equality within the couple or family's own relationships.

Marriage and family therapists can use video games and the roles that men occupy within them to open up conversations with couples and families about how these ideals might be seen within their own relationships. For example, a therapist might ask each partner and/or family member which characters they most identify with, and which ones are perceived as weak, submissive, and complicit or which ones are seen as strong and dominant. They might ask what role the male characters have in the game, and further explore the role of female or non-binary characters. Furthermore, in order for marriage and family therapists to address sexism within couples and families, the therapist can ask clients how those characters might rather be portrayed (i.e. strong and well-armored instead of strong but scantily clad

and hardly protected by armor). Attitudes and roles of characters can also be explored while attuning to egalitarian themes. A therapist might then ask the couple or family to work together to imagine a video game in which the video game characters upheld egalitarian rather than sexist beliefs. The therapist might be curious about what that might look like in the video game, and what that might look like as applied to the couple or family's own relationship(s). While therapists can approach the value of equality within relationships in many ways, talking about inequalities within couple and family relationships as expressed by power imbalances in video game characters may make talking about inequalities a little bit more comfortable within the therapy room.

Case example

Addressing inequalities on- and off-line

Sofia, 35, seeks the help of a marriage and family therapist to address her relationship with John, 31. She has been frustrated for months due to picking up most of the housework duties and feeling like John is not addressing housework duties like he normally would. The therapist learns that they are both avid gamers who both spend time speaking to his core group of friends in an online chat. During chat and in game, Sofia is often relegated to the support role in their current multiplayer game while John plays as a leading male character. Playing both as a support character and feeling unappreciated in the game chat, Sofia opts to take a break from the game while John increases his playing time with the same group of people.

The therapist opens up the conversation with Sofia to see how this game play has shaped her experiences recently and to see how she perceives her support character. John is also included in this conversation but only after Sofia finishes her reflections. Both partners explore the role of male, female, non-binary, and support characters in the game and also explore what it might be like for partners to switch up character selection for future games. The therapist also explores the potential for inequalities to exist outside of game play while also connecting it to inequalities found in their household duties and attitudes.

Addressing power and disempowerment

Marriage and family therapists who employ a feminist family therapy perspective seek to empower women through uncovering power they already possess. As demonstrated in the research, many female video game characters are disempowered through their sexualization and objectification, especially in regard to their clothing and physical appearance (Burgess, Stermer, & Burgess, 2007; Dill et al., 2008; Dill & Thill, 2007; Martins et al., 2009; Scharrer, 2004).

To address sexism as it applies to video games and relationships, marriage and family therapists might help all gamers analyze power differentials between video game characters and then look at similarities and differences of those power differentials as applied to their relationship(s). Depending on the nature of the video game, marriage and family therapists can use video games, whether in session or for homework, to help the disempowered partner or family member experience and explore what it is like to be the “powerful” video game character. This concept can also be applied to the reverse situation, in which the partner or family member with most of the power can play the “disempowered” video game character and explore what that experience is like for them. Therapists can then have the partners or family members reflect on their experiences and work together to restructure dysfunctional power patterns in their relationship(s).

Some young male gamers who identify with the male characters in games that utilize sexist and violent messages show less empathy towards female victims of violence (Grabmeier, 2016). To examine power without the examination of violence, toxic or hegemonic masculinity, and misogyny is to neglect a feminist framework in general. Utilizing a power and control lens, power issues can be explored in therapy where one gamer is consuming games and language that exaggerate sexualized female images and images that normalize the perpetration of violence in video games and media. Assessment and screening of overt influence of power and control to examine both in-game and out-of-game considerations is vital. Considering that all power is not inherently negative or leads to direct harm, a therapist must consider instances where a non-male gamer in a couple or family system feels empowered by certain video games or characters.

Case example

Disempowerment through marginalization

Annie, 16, comes to her first therapy with her mother Andrea, 39. Andrea mentions that Annie has been withdrawing from her extracurricular activities and has been “distant” at home and school. Annie comes home from school and retreats to her room, often preferring to play on her PlayStation 4 console. Andrea mentions that she supports her daughter playing video games, but she reports concern that her recent distant behaviors are even seen when Annie plays her video games, as before she would hear Annie speak in game to friends and now she does not.

The marriage and family therapist starts to invite Annie into the conversation to gather background information about what types of video games she prefers. She replies that she likes almost all video games and they join for several minutes over games that Annie has played recently. The therapist also asks questions to Annie about her recent distant behaviors. Annie mentions

feeling like she is somewhat distant, mostly because she has “no power” and she would just rather be alone. Throughout this session, Annie appears withdrawn.

For the next session, the therapist works with Annie individually. She brings Annie into the play therapy room and invites her to play a multi-player video game with her. The therapist intentionally does not do well in the game and highlights Annie’s strengths throughout their gameplay to really emphasize ways in which Annie does have strength and power.

Several sessions of joining result in Annie opening up to recent heterosexist and sexist comments she has experienced online in various chat forums for gamers. She discloses to the therapist that she thinks she may be queer but no one else knows, and she describes feeling marginalized, disempowered, and alone in this identity. The therapist suggests the game *Gone Home*, which is a single-player exploration game for that PS4 that centers around a queer teenager in-game. Gameplay is assigned as homework for Annie to complete with the therapist adding that she would like Annie to bring to session what it was like to play a video game character who is both queer and female. The therapist’s intention for this homework assignment is to expose her to a story that centers around a queer female teenager, which are underrepresented identities in the gaming industry that contribute to an atmosphere of disempowerment. Not only will this give Annie a character to identify with, it will also allow her to further explore how her video game character explores themes of power and control. This gameplay opens several discussions up about how Annie experiences these same concepts in her own life, and Annie finds that she becomes more comfortable with her identities as a video gamer who is both a woman and queer. She begins to feel more “in power.”

Enhancing women’s strengths

One goal for using feminist family therapy with gamers is to emphasize and value all women’s experiences and foster awareness of their strengths. According to Walker (1990), the enhancement of women’s strengths is facilitated with the help of the feminist therapist by teaching women to look for their own strengths and how to use them effectively. In the context of video games, a feminist family therapist can have a client identify strengths that they possess by having the client describe heroines in their favorite games. Additionally, the therapist can explore shared strengths the client and the heroine have in common through a client’s preferred language. Fostering awareness of these strengths can also be harnessed by suggesting video games where there is a strong female lead to the client in efforts of self-exploration and development. In addition, this technique allows for additional joining benefits for the client as the therapeutic relationship is strengthened in session by a therapist acknowledging a client’s expertise in game and out of game.

In couple or family sessions, couples and families can foster and develop connection through seeking out strengths both in-game and out-of-game. Holding space for this exploration can create shifts in games and relationships from overt or subtle oppression and marginalization to mutual understanding and appreciation. One example with couples specifically is the obvious shift away from that of a “gamer girlfriend” label, or someone known to play with their partner as a support role. Each partner or family member can identify strengths of women outside of gameplay and the woman’s character inside of the game.

Case example

Addressing social anxiety with women’s strengths

Amanda is a 22-year-old individual who first comes to therapy for issues related to social anxiety. In the first session, the therapist assesses Amanda for her current self-care practices. During this conversation, Amanda states that after a long day at work she often sets aside time to play her favorite video game as a way of relaxing. The therapist elicits further details about her favorite video games by asking her what genre of video games she likes and what kinds of characters she plays. Amanda states that she prefers massively multiplayer online role-playing games and is often drawn to characters who would be categorized as strong women. The therapist asks additional details about what her favorite strong woman character is like, and Amanda describes her favorite character as one who is cunning and smart, skilled in martial arts, and revered as an excellent trainer to several character heroes. The therapist expresses amazement at such a character and asks her what it is like to play this particular character. The client expresses that she has found it fun to play someone who is the exact opposite of her in real life, and further explains that Amanda herself is shy around others, does not leave her house much, and struggles to even form a complete sentence in the presence of others due to an intense fear of rejection. Before the end of the session, the therapist asks Amanda to complete a homework assignment in which she has to look for ways that she is already like this favorite woman character throughout the week.

During the next session and over the course of several additional ones, the client shares stories and experiences of how, like her favorite character, she is able to use her cunningness to outsmart The Social Anxiety’s desire to keep her from interacting with others. With this woman character as her role model, she works on fostering her inner strength to attend a martial arts class and interact with other martial art students there. Along the way, she continues to identify ways in which she utilizes her shared strengths with her favorite video game character to accomplish this feat.

Accepting and validating feelings

Walker (1990) described the benefit of acceptance and validation of the feelings that clients bring to therapy. These benefits can be addressed when feminist family therapists employ self-disclosure in an attempt to remove the “we-they” barrier seen in traditional therapeutic relationships (Walker, 1990). Ideally, self-disclosure can help the therapeutic relationship by equalizing the dynamics. This is done with mirroring and modeling to the client in efforts of encouraging them to make an informed decision regarding topics discussed in session. According to Nichols (2013), there is a fine line between staying neutral and imposing personal and political beliefs onto the client. To help with this, a therapist can discuss and explore topics such as sexism and sexual harassment in video games and society, but ultimately leave the decision for the client to make. This informed choice can then be explored in sessions and adapted to newer principles.

Self-disclosure should be authentic and communicate to the client that they are not alone in sexism-based struggles. An example of self-disclosure is when a client discusses feeling objectified at a video game convention after hearing misogynistic language about her dressing up as Lara Croft, from *Tomb Raider*. A therapist can disclose either experiencing a similar situation or other instances of feeling objectified while also normalizing thoughts, feelings, and actions. This can facilitate the exploration and analysis of internalized sexism, sexist societal beliefs, and sexist stereotypes. Essentially, this validation may lead towards the adoption of a feminist identity while having the client challenge misogynistic and oppressive perspectives taught in game. Systemically, the therapist and the client can identify the influences of social, cultural, political, and economic contexts on the client’s experiences as well as explore the influences their relationships provide.

Case example

Self-disclosure, social location, and exploration of identities in group therapy

Ashley, a marriage and family therapist starts her second group therapy session for gamers of color that attunes to people who are gender and sexually diverse. In these group therapy sessions, she psychoeducates about sexism and its intersections with race, ethnicity, gender, and other cultural contexts. She shares her social location and identities within the group to facilitate dialogue with other group members. She mentions that she is a queer Afro Latina trans woman and comes from a lower socioeconomic status. She continues this dialogue by explaining her experiences within video games, the video game community, and video game conventions. By careful examination, she continues to employ self-disclosure about her identities while leaving space for others to contribute to the conversation and

make the decision to contribute if they would like. She makes it a priority to explore and normalize feelings, thoughts, and behaviors while challenging the status quo and any internalized misogyny that group members display.

Therapeutic considerations

The use of feminist family therapy to address sexism in gaming is proposed for individual clients and within the context of couples, family systems and within communities. Clients of all ages including children, adolescents, and adults can benefit from exploring these themes as applied to their video game playing. When working with individuals, this technique is broadened beyond individual concerns to address systemic and relational themes such as sexism and the client's relationship networks. Considering that sexism is an institutionalized, pervasive, and systemic problem, we propose a culturally sensitive, feminist, and systemic framework to address the issues that gamers may face within their couple and family relationships.

This technique is applicable to any individual, family, or couple who plays video games or utilizes different avenues of media. Media sources have the potential to project sexualized content. Assessment in the form of unstructured interviews as well as during intake session can capture information about media consumption such as video game play, music, television, movies and other forms. Assessment also provides a therapist with information about appropriateness of using this technique and attuning to these issues in therapy. It is recommended that attuning to video games in therapy complement a marriage and family therapist's already established assessment tools and intake procedures while exploring possible barriers. We suggest that initial conversations start within the joining process, as this provides a therapist with information regarding in-game and out-of-game information about clients. Assessments that measure sexism and other contextual issues (i.e., racism, heterosexism, and other forms of marginalizing practices) can be given to examine both covert and overt forms of oppression. All assessment practices provide additional information about potential barriers and benefits for use of these techniques.

As an interactive medium, video game play is a unique form of media as it combines multiple different types of entertainment in the form of imagery, storytelling, audio and other forms while a client most likely will be a participant in these forms. A client does not have to be actively playing video games for this technique to be utilized. One example of this is clients who might engage in the viewing of streaming services (e.g., *Twitch & YouTube Gaming*) but not participating in these games might still experience sexism in the form of online harassment and misogynistic language use.

There is a benefit for those clients who are open to discussing video game and media content in therapy—one example is a therapist using a client's

preferred language and metaphors during the course of treatment. Attuning to a client's interests (i.e., gaming and other medias) can provide a client with comfort during the intake and future sessions. Using games in session for therapeutic purposes provide the client the ability to be placed in the expert role within session. A therapist can connect the medium of video game language to a client's presenting problem such as sexism, disempowerment, or self-esteem issues to help facilitate these benefits. A potential challenge includes working relationally with couples and families in which only one person enjoys or plays video games. Assessment of the benefits should be considered when working with clients.

Multi-disciplinary collaboration

While marriage and family therapists may collaborate with their clients to address sexism between all types of gamers, they cannot do it alone. Collaboration efforts with video game developers, core faculty at video game programs within colleges and universities, and the gaming community is essential for helping address this issue. Examples of how to create a collaborative relationship with these systems are discussed.

Video game developers

Feminism concepts have not been entirely adopted within the video game industry and community. The video game community is still referenced as a male-dominated industry and needs to be addressed (Wingfield, 2014). As video games continue to depict negative stereotypes and roles (i.e., women having exaggerated body parts such as breasts and women being portrayed as prostitutes) the increased need for more women and gender non-conforming developers is vital, especially because there are only about 12% of developers in the industry that are women (Cunningham, 2011). The creation of video game companies and video games that have a feminist focus are needed and can potentially increase this percentage. Collaborating with these few game developers can increase the amount of game developers who emphasize important feminist topics and themes.

Women in the gaming industry need to be included in larger roles within their respective fields. This includes all women having the space to express concerns over representation in the production, marketing, and advertising stages. Reduction of the gender gap in companies include women holding more leadership, senior, and executive positions. In addition, lack of harassment including sexual harassment policies at companies in addition to social media policies allow for male power in a male-dominated industry to assert this power. Marriage and family therapists can help collaborate in the form of empowering women and holding others accountable.

In order to get at the root of sexism within video games, marriage and family therapists can work in partnership with the gaming industry by establishing a working relationship between all of the developers, artists, and development teams who create video games. The authors conceptualize this similarly to a consultant role and having that consultant address multiple components within working relationships. Often, video game companies reach out to consultants to produce accuracy, legitimacy, and cultural information to their video game. One example is Ubisoft's *Assassin's Creed: Origins* reaching out to a historian to depict and recreate Egypt accurately (Ore, 2017). A marriage and family therapist can provide consultation on both providing inclusivity and representation while minimizing marginalizing and systemic sexism in video games.

A relationship that addresses women's issues such as power, feminism, and other topics can be seen in multiple areas. This work starts with having critical conversations regarding privilege, power, and intersectionality and how these themes might influence decision-making purposes in initial game developing. Deconstructing potential idealized gamers while considering marginalized characters is essential in the gaming industry. Addressing male and white privilege effects on their audience, non-male coworkers, and community is also an important consideration for industry professionals.

Additional critical conversations include addressing stereotypes, especially for marginalized gamers. A therapist can get a buy-in with developers as part of their job is to consider their audience and who they are creating their games for and therapists can use their expertise on sexism and marginalization to help address that developers have an increased need to hold these critical conversations with therapists, as many are currently addressing backlash associated with creating female and other marginalized video game leads.

Core faculty at video game colleges and universities

Women's issues continue to be underrepresented within video games and among research, as there is a larger focus solely on aggression and addiction within video game literature. By reaching out to game developers who are core faculty at video game colleges and universities, marriage and family therapists and researchers can collaborate with industry and academic professionals to increase the exposure of women's issues in video games and academic research. Adding systemic and intersectional perspectives to a collaborative relationship can be seen in various academic conferences, video game and media centered academic journals, internships, and within the university community.

A marriage and family therapist can also help create a diversity statement within an academic program that emphasizes and is committed to diversity. A

statement can have students adhere to the ongoing commitment to a foundation that seeks to understand and support individuals whose sex, gender identity and expression, age, race, color, ethnicity, sexual orientation, socioeconomic status, veteran status, marital status, parental status, religion, spirituality, disability, health status, political beliefs, national origin or ancestry, genetic information, immigration status, or language might be different than their own status (Diversity Statement, [n.d.](#), para. 2). This commitment can be upheld in person, in their community, and within the creation of a game.

Future research in this collaboration may appear as video games within therapeutic environments continue to rise. The popularity of video games among clients may qualify video games as a useful tool in psychotherapy, resulting in further research efforts in the mental health field (Ceranoglu, 2010). Several video game and mental health professional collaborations currently exist at this time. The Play Nice Institute designs, tests, and implements mental health initiatives with experts across a group of multidisciplinary groups of academic, developmental, and clinical psychologists with game designers, artists, and programmers (Partners, [n.d.](#)). In addition, iThrive Games partners with teens, game designers, and mental health professionals and educators to create projects with a preventative and therapeutic focus (iThrive Games, 2018). This collaboration includes game developers and mental health professionals creating games in therapeutic contexts. This multidisciplinary approach will further continue the collaboration between mental health professionals and merge it within the game development community in hopes of using a critical and theoretical analysis of video games and systemic issues such as sexism. Until video games and video game communities that use misogynistic language are devoid of negative sexist content, the push for this work is necessary across multiple fields, including starting within educational systems.

Helpfulness of collaboration

We propose that a feminist-informed marriage and family therapist can collaborate with a game developer or researcher within core faculty in video game programs to address the gender misrepresentation, gender-based violence, sexism, cissexism, traditional gender roles, sexual objectification and other topics that need to be addressed within the video game industry. Collaborating with researchers, clinicians, and practicing therapists such as feminist family therapists can help create games with accurate portrayals of all women. There needs to be a special focus on the experiences of women of color and lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer (LGBTQ+) issues due to our desire of implementing feminism that is intersectional. Additional research for the trans+ community in both this topic and other research topics is vital as not all female gamers identify as women.

The engagement of all types of gamers will address themes of feminism within a larger context such as video games and media. We assume that engagement of feminism and feminist family therapy concepts through a systemic lens and through this popular platform will increase the much-needed message of gender equality. We also assume that it will empower women to pursue engagement in science, technology, engineering, art, and math (STEAM) fields if these games are utilized during childhood, adolescence, and throughout early adulthood. Creating feminist-friendly games and media that encourage messages of empowerment, strong quality characters and narratives, and new emerging non-male heroines can be created and facilitate a shift in the video game culture and community.

We recommend that marriage and family therapists who use a feminist family therapy approach reach out to developers that are already pushing for progressiveness in the form of women's and gender equality within the gaming industry. These developers and their companies are already producing games that empower people of all genders rather than push a misogynistic agenda. Video game developers and their publishers that produce games such as *The Last of Us*, *Tomb Raider* (2013), *Gone Home*, and *Beyond: Two Souls* provide gamers with strong female protagonists and stories. This ultimately provides gamers with better representations of women and girls in games, in efforts of improving the current video game industry's culture.

In addition, feminist-informed marriage and family therapists can empower current video game programs in colleges and universities to implement curriculum to include feminist topics such as gender-based violence, gender roles, and other themes. Research can be continually completed at programs with which core faculty are also gaming professionals or developers. Additionally, there can be an emphasis on research implementing feminism in current graduate programs or technology-based Ph.D. programs to head start a shift in the gaming industry towards a more inclusive and equality-based environments.

Community collaboration

Implementation of these ideas include reaching out to gamers themselves through various environments such as video game conferences and comic, gaming and entertainment conventions. Doing so would reach different types of gamers throughout multiple major cities and countries. Popular gaming conventions such as Penny Arcade Expo (PAX) East and West and Electronic Entertainment Expo (E3) allow individuals to play new games before their release, meet industry leaders, and learn gaming technology and information through panels. One convention in particular, GeekGirlCon, which is located in Seattle, Washington, provides the outlet to disseminate information about feminist family therapy and video games in a panel for gamers and industry professionals to learn and engage in. GeekGirlCon's mission statement includes:

Celebrating and honoring the legacy of women contributing to science and technology; comics, arts, and literature; and game play and game design by connecting geeky women worldwide and creating community to foster continued growth of women in geek culture through events (Mission & Values, 2017).

Additionally, GeekGirlCon lists values that their convention upholds which include values related to community, empowerment, diversity and inclusivity in their events. Marriage and family therapists and game developers who want to promote feminist family therapy tools can participate in this event as they work to create a supportive, positive culture that celebrates the achievements of all women, including trans women gamers. Lastly, they strive to be representative of diverse groups and communities embracing all ages, gender identities, sexual orientations, ethnicities, races, physical and mental abilities and more. This inclusivity will provide the base for marriage and family therapists to do outreach with GeekGirlCon with regards to intersectionality and feminist family therapy techniques.

Conventions that facilitate togetherness within the gaming community also foster self-expression with most players doing costume play “cosplay” of their favorite characters (i.e. Lara Croft from *Tomb Raider*, Samus from *Metroid*, and Princess Zelda from the *Legend of Zelda*, etc.). The ability to portray their favorite characters as well as alter their costumes, such as altering their armor, provides self-expression, promotes creativity, and increases control for female gamers. To further facilitate togetherness at these events, marriage and family therapists who use a feminist family therapy lens can address popular issues rampant in the sexual harassment spheres of the gaming community such as combating slut-shaming and oversexualization.

It is important to note that there currently are groups that already work to address issues related to sexual harassment and sexism within the gaming community. For example, according to Romano (2014), a group of cosplayers created *Cosplay is Not Consent*, to address and combat sexual harassment and stereotyping at conventions and entertainment expos. Marriage and family therapists should petition for the involvement of groups such as *Cosplay is Not Consent* at comic and gaming conventions to further promote empowerment for all gamers at these events. Last, outreach with a group such as *Cosplay is Not Consent* can allow feminist-informed gamers and marriage and family therapists a platform to psychoeducate gamers at these conventions about how women are sometimes depicted in video games, specifically as sexualized objects who are not as important or respected as their male counterparts. This could be addressed in panel that facilitates an open conversation with audiences at conventions. Questions near the end of the panel can facilitate gamers in the audience to speak up about their own related personal stories, thoughts, and feelings.

Conclusion

The video game industry continually needs to make strides to address the misrepresentation and underrepresentation of all women, including trans women in video games. Sexism and negative stereotypes within video games and the gaming industry is an area that needs to diminish, considering the large number of gamers who are women and young girls. While advocating for a shift in this field, marriage and family therapists can assist gamers affected by sexism and harassment with feminist family therapy techniques. Therapists can use video games to address issues pertaining to equality and power within relationships. Therapists can pull strengths that the gamers have in game while emphasizing acceptance and validation. In addition, to advance these themes in therapeutic settings, marriage and family therapists should advocate for change using a multidisciplinary collaboration with individuals within the video game industry. Collaboration with developers and industry professionals at events such as video game conventions that have both players and industry leaders attending, ensures efforts of proving equality and consciousness within the gaming community.

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